LS constituency, a determined Sharmila has thrown down the gauntlet to Jagan. Her main grouse is Jagan fielding their cousin, Y.S. Avinash Reddy, the sitting Kadapa MP, who was allegedly connected with the murder of their uncle and former Kadapa MP Y.S. Vivekananda Reddy (a brother of late former CM and Jagan-Sharmila's father Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy) in the run up to the 2019 election. While the case remains unsolved, Jagan has given a clean chit to Avinash and got a boost when the Kadapa district court ordered on April 16 that Sharmila and TDP leaders could not make defamatory comments related to the murder. Jagan, thus, faces two formidable adversarial blocs.

and the state) for revival," Modi said at a May 6 rally at Vemagiri in Rajamahendravaram constituency from where BJP state chief D. Purandeswari (Naidu's sister-in-law) is contesting. Modi accused the YSRCP of pushing the state into a debt trap and termed the state's irrigation and housing schemes abject failures. The PM's three visits to the state were focused largely on drawing support for the six BJP contestants to the Lok Sabha.

The Jagan Outreach

Jagan's campaign strategy for the LS and assembly polls was rolled out over four months. He hit the road in earnest only after announcing the names of all the contestants on March 16, though he did attempt to garner some early momentum with four massive regional Siddham (Ready) rallies, starting from January 27 in Visakhapatnam. The next phase, Memantha Siddham (We are ready), involved a 21-day bus tour of all 26 districts from late March with multiple meetings, whistle-stops and a rally at the end of each day. This was followed by Siddham Sabhas (readiness rallies) at select places to firm up support for the YSRCP and counter rival narratives. As a novel sideshow, the YSRCP deployed 12 common citizens as star campaigners to underscore its people-centric, welfare-oriented governance. The chosen persons spoke of how their families have gained from the

UNDER THE JAGAN KOSAM SIDDHAM OUTREACH, 250,000 PARTY CADRES VISITED 16.7 MILLION HOMES, SINGING JAGAN'S PRAISES. THE YSRCP BELIEVES IT HAS TOUCHED MOST NEEDY PEOPLE

For the two main belligerents, aggressive campaigning, with a focus on reaching out to a maximum number of voters, has been the norm. While Jagan is concerned about some pockets of anti-incumbency, Naidu is worried by how a perceived want of opposition unity—some sections of the BJP oppose the tie-up with the TDP—will hurt his prospects.

Some of the NDA's worries would have been allayed by visits of high-profile BJP leaders, led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi himself. "The YSRCP government has crippled Andhra Pradesh with rampant corruption and it requires double engine growth (an NDA government in both Delhi

By Amarnath K. Menon

For a decade now, actor-politician Pawan Kalyan has been trying to emerge as an influential force in the electoral politics of Andhra Pradesh, banking on his Kapu caste cohort. Despite a series of defeats and setbacks, the 'Power Star' is optimistic that his star will shine by playing second fiddle to Telugu Desam Party (TDP) supremo N. Chandrababu Naidu. Pawan's Jana Sena Party (JSP) is contesting 20 of the 175 assembly seats and two of the 25 Lok Sabha constituencies that will go to the polls on May 13. Both Lok Sabha candidates and 10 of the assembly contestants are from his community.

Pawan launched his party in March 2014, but did not contest the elections that year. He rather joined hands with the National Democratic Alliance (NDA), speaking alongside Narendra Modi and Naidu in Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and Karnataka, helping Naidu come to power in the first election of the bifurcated state. In 2019, the JSP contested in all 175 assembly constituencies, forming a bloc with both communist parties and the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), and was routed. Pawan lost in both seats he contested from, Gajuwaka and Bhimavaram, and his party's lone winner from Razole later switched to the ruling Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP), which scored a landslide win.

Sensing united they could stand, Pawan, at first, struck an alliance with the TDP while the BJP held out. He worked overtime in aligning and addressing joint meetings with Naidu for about a year in preparing for the polls. Then, in recent months, in rallying to fight under the banner of the NDA, he conceded an additional Lok Sabha constituency to the BJP. His efforts have helped consolidate the alliance and the BJP is contesting in six Lok Sabha and 10 assembly seats.

Pawan believes the NDA can edge out the YSRCP given that both the JSP and TDP enjoy a 45 per cent vote share and need to add from the remaining 10 per cent to emerge the